That said, digital-era technologies are even more amenable to centralization of ownership in fewer hands with their efficiency in the use of intelligence in production and delivery of services. What the world is witnessing today in the form of dominance of social media by a few digital technology companies is the testimony of that centralization and concentration power. As a consequence, the digital revolution is likely to further accentuate social and governance issues.

There are fewer environmental issues with the digital economy but the social and governance issues are likely to get more accentuated.

The World Adopts a Sustainable Development Agenda

In September 2015, all countries, under the aegis of the United Nations, adopted seventeen Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) as the ‘plan of action for people, planet and prosperity’. These seventeen goals, which came into force in January 2016, represent the global ESG agenda.

All countries and stakeholders, acting in collaborative partnership, are expected to implement this plan. The social agenda is most eloquently captured in the resolve ‘to free the human race from the tyranny of poverty and want’ and the goal ‘to realize the human rights of all and to achieve gender equality and the empowerment of all women and girls’. The environmental agenda is captured in the commitment ‘to heal and secure our planet’. The governance agenda, in a way, is encapsulated in the determination ‘to take the bold and transformative steps which are urgently needed to shift the world on to a sustainable and resilient path’. The SDGs ‘are integrated and indivisible and balance the three dimensions of sustainable development’.

The seventeen goals detail different dimensions of the social, environmental and governance agenda.

While the SDG agenda is quite ambitious, though unduly verbose and detailed (there are 189 targets as well), it does not deal directly with the real